

Foundational types of AI agents

AI agents use artificial intelligence to perceive their environment, make decisions and take actions to achieve specific goals. They can operate with varying degrees of autonomy, from following simple rules to learning from experience. Understanding the foundational types provides a base for seeing their enterprise potential.

Agent type	Description	Example use cases
Simple reflex agents	Use "condition-action" rules to respond to immediate stimuli.	Automated devices that adjust or react directly to their environment.
Model-based reflex agents	Use an internal model of the world, enabling better decision-making in partially	Self-driving cars that predict vehicle movements.

observable
environments.

**Goal-based
agents**

Make decisions
by considering
future actions
that achieve
specific goals.

Autonomous
drones planning
optimal routes.

**Utility-based
agents**

Evaluate options
based on a
utility function to
maximize overall
outcomes and
resolve
conflicting goals.

Recommendation
systems
suggesting
personalized
products.

**Learning
agents**

Improve
performance by
learning from
feedback and
experience over
time.

AI personal
assistants that
refine interactions
by analyzing user
behaviors.

Task agents	Single-purpose agents designed to execute specific tasks with structured input and output.	Automating invoice matching in accounts payable, processing citizen service requests.
Collaboration agents	Conversational agents designed for iterative dialogue with users.	Enable users to ask natural language questions and receive context-aware answers from enterprise content sources.
RAG agents	Use AI agents to manage the Retrieval-Augmented Generation process, intelligently querying	Advanced question-answering systems and internal knowledge management portals.

multiple
knowledge
sources to
provide richer
context to LLMs.

**Enterprise
agents**

Higher-order
agents that
orchestrate both
task agents and
collaboration
agents to tackle
complex,
industry-specific
problems.

Intelligent medical
records review,
financial claims
assessment and
loan exception
processing.